

Worn down

From the moment a mountain begins to form, it also starts to be worn away. Rain and wind break up rocks in the mountains, and rivers carry them downstream.

See also

Learn more about continents (22–23) and rivers (36–37).

Winding rivers can help carve rocks into high ridges or hills.

Flattening out

Over time, mountains disappear—as rivers, rain, and wind erode the rock and carry it to the sea. Erosion eventually flattens mountains into vast areas of flat land, called plains.

Mount Everest is the highest mountain on Earth. It is 29,029 ft (8,848 m) high.

The Andes Not all mountains are formed from the collision of two tectonic plates. Some form when one plate is dragged down under another one. This is how the Andes in South America were formed.



Summits in space Mountains are not found just on Earth, but also on the moon and some planets. A mountain called Maxwell Montes on Venus is about 7 miles (11 km) high.



Marine mountaineers Many mountaintops are made of rocks that originally formed in ancient oceans! These rocks contain fossils of marine animals, such as ammonites—extinct relatives of the squid.

